iSideload

A lean, self-contained Mac sideloader for iOS

Log in with a free Apple ID → auto-provision a cert → sign → install to your iPhone or iPad.
No Xcode. No AltStore server. No Python. One notarized menu-bar app.

v0.1-alpha | Notarized · Developer ID | AGPL-3.0 | github.com/johnbuckman/iSideload

Current state · July 2026

CURRENT STATE

A complete, shipped product

The whole lean-AltServer pipeline works end-to-end and is published as a notarized app.

Free-Apple-ID login

Sign in with any Apple ID (SMS 2-factor). iSideload auto-mints a signing certificate and 7-day profile for you.

Signs on the Mac

Uses Apple-equivalent signing (zsign) to sign all 64 embedded frameworks — no on-device signer, no Xcode.

Self-contained

Bundles OpenSSL, libimobiledevice and the signer. No Python, no Homebrew, no AltServer. Just the app.

Auto-refresh

Re-signs before the 7-day cert expires — on a timer and the moment a device connects.

Multi-account & multi-device

Manage several Apple IDs and several iPhones/iPads from one menu-bar window.

Notarized & open source

v0.1-alpha DMG is notarized (zero Gatekeeper warnings). Public under AGPL-3.0.

HOW IT WORKS

One login → an app on your device

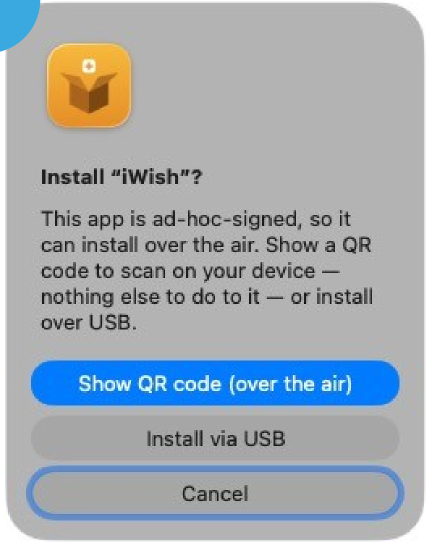
1. **Log in**
   Free Apple ID
   + SMS 2FA
2. **Provision**
   Auto cert +
   7-day profile
3. **Sign**
   zsign all 64
   frameworks
4. **Install**
   libimobiledevice
   over USB
5. **Refresh**
   Auto re-sign
   before expiry

Steps 1–2 need you once. After that, refresh runs unattended.

Over the air — install over Wi-Fi

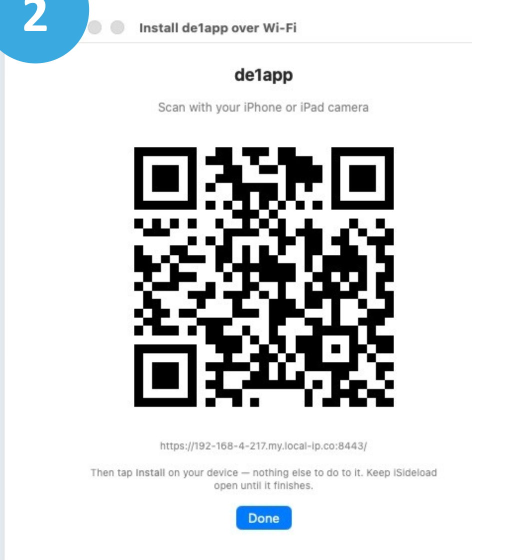
When the .ipa is signed by a paid Apple Developer account with an ad-hoc provisioning profile, iSideload serves it over local HTTPS and the device installs it itself — no cable, no lockdown tunnel.

1



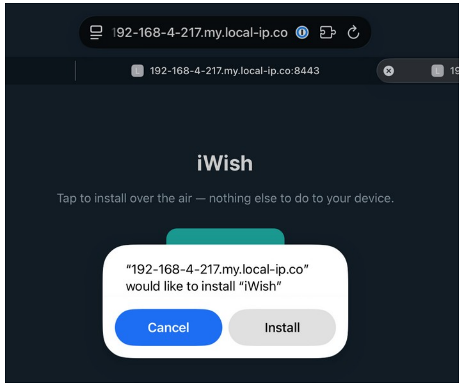
iSideload sees the ad-hoc signature → Show QR code

2



Scan the QR code with the device camera

3



Tap Install — right on the device, over Wi-Fi

4

Done — the app is on the home screen

THE RELIABLE PATH

USB install is known to work

✓ 100% reliable

Plug the device in, and the full flow — trust, sign, install — just works.

~3 s	64	iOS 26
typical USB install	frameworks signed	validated end-to-end

Auto-trust on first plug-in

iSideload flips on Wi-Fi visibility over the cable, so no manual setup.

Fast & deterministic

A 76 MB app installs in ~3.5 s. No flaky discovery, no timeouts.

The guaranteed fallback

Whenever Wi-Fi refresh can't reach a device, USB always completes.

FREE ACCOUNTS

Stack Apple IDs for more apps

A free Apple ID signs 3 apps at a time. Add another account and you add another 3 slots — all managed in one window.

Apple ID #1
3 / 3 slots

- iWish
- de1app
- Beacon

Apple ID #2
3 / 3 slots

- App four
- App five
- App six

Apple ID #3
3 / 3 slots

- App seven
- App eight
- App nine

✓ **One cert per account, persisted and reused —** re-signing one app never invalidates its siblings.

PAID DEVELOPER ACCOUNT

$99 / year lifts every limit

The same login works with a paid Apple Developer account — iSideload reads it automatically and unlocks the paid tier.

Free Apple ID

- **7-day signing window**
  Apps stop opening after a week unless refreshed
- **3 apps per account**
  Stack accounts to get more
- **~10 App IDs / week**
  New bundle IDs are rate-limited

Paid — $99/yr

- ✓ **1-year signing window**
  Sign once, use for a full year — refresh almost never needed
- ✓ **More apps & App IDs**
  Room for many apps without juggling accounts
- ✓ **Rock-solid for daily use**
  Best for apps you actually depend on

iSideload shows a per-account validity badge — "7 days" for free, "1 year" for paid — so you always know which you're on.

THE INTERFACE

A menu-bar app that manages itself

iSideload

Lives in your Mac menu bar

What the window gives you

- **Lives in the menu bar**

  No Dock clutter — a shipping-box icon you click when you need it.

- **Per-app management**

  Each app shows its device, expiry countdown, Refresh and Remove.

- **Slots & validity at a glance**

  "2 / 3 slots", "7 days" vs "1 year" badges per account.

- **Install from URL, .json or .ipa**

  Load an AltStore-style source, or pick an IPA from disk.

- **Launches at login**

  Registers itself so refresh keeps running quietly in the background.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Wi-Fi updating — still being solved

The goal: refresh apps over Wi-Fi so you never re-plug. Discovery works; the install path is fighting the home network.

✓ Already working

✓ **Wi-Fi install on iOS 26**

Verified: a signed app installs over Wi-Fi in ~14 s when the device is reachable and unlocked.

✓ **Device→Mac beacon**

An on-device ping reaches the Mac straight through the mesh — the Mac learns the device IP with zero scanning.

✓ **Direct-IP / subnet sweep**

Handles DHCP and mesh Wi-Fi by connecting to the device by IP, bypassing Apple's flaky Bonjour discovery.

! The remaining blocker

→ **Mac→device high ports get reset**

On the home Eero mesh, the dynamic install ports are intermittently blocked, even with the device awake and unlocked.

→ **iOS sandbox blocks self-install**

An on-device app can't reach the device's own install service, so a simple relay isn't possible.

→ **Next: a device-initiated tunnel**

Outbound-from-device path (SideStore-style) to sidestep the inbound block — the piece being prototyped now.

✓ **For paid + ad-hoc IPAs, Wi-Fi install already works today (slide 4).** This blocker is only the free-account refresh case.

Where iSideload stands

- **Shipped** — Notarized v0.1-alpha DMG, public AGPL-3.0 repo, fully self-contained.
- **USB: solid** — One-plug sign-and-install in seconds — the guaranteed path.
- **Accounts: flexible** — 3 apps per free ID, stack accounts, or go $99/yr for a full year.
- **Wi-Fi: in progress** — Discovery solved; a device-initiated tunnel is the next step.

Try it

github.com/
johnbuckman/
iSideload